

PPC Fundamentals — Quick Start Guide

Amazon PPC basics for a new virtual assistant: campaign types, match types, core metrics, and a first-30-days checklist.

What Amazon PPC Is

Amazon PPC (pay-per-click) is Amazon's auction-based advertising system. Sellers bid on keywords or products; Amazon shows ads in search results and product pages; the advertiser pays only when a shopper clicks. Your job as a PPC virtual assistant is to turn ad spend into profitable sales — not just clicks.

The Three Campaign Types

Type	Where it shows	Best for
Sponsored Products (SP)	Search results, product detail pages	Driving sales on individual ASINs; the workhorse of most accounts
Sponsored Brands (SB)	Top of search, custom headline + logo	Brand awareness, driving traffic to a storefront or multi-product listing
Sponsored Display (SD)	Off-Amazon and on-Amazon placements, re-targeting	Re-engaging shoppers who viewed but didn't buy; defending against competitors

Match Types (Sponsored Products)

- **Broad** — widest reach, matches related searches; highest volume, lowest precision. Good for keyword discovery.
- **Phrase** — matches searches containing the keyword phrase in order. Middle ground.
- **Exact** — matches only the keyword (and close variants). Highest precision, best for proven winners.

Core Metrics Glossary

Metric	Formula	What it tells you
CTR	Clicks ÷ Impressions	How compelling your ad is (image, price, title, reviews)
CVR	Orders ÷ Clicks	How well the listing converts once a shopper clicks
CPC	Spend ÷ Clicks	Average price paid per click
ACOS	Spend ÷ Ad Sales	Ad cost as a percentage of the sales it generated — lower is more efficient
ROAS	Ad Sales ÷ Spend	The inverse of ACOS, expressed as a multiple (e.g. 4x)
TACOS	Ad Spend ÷ Total Sales	How much of the whole business's revenue is going to ads — the metric that matters to the business

How the Auction Works, Briefly

Amazon ranks eligible ads mainly by bid × relevance for the search. You don't need the highest bid to win a placement, but bidding too low means your ad rarely shows. Actual cost per click is typically just above the next-highest competitive bid, not your full bid.

First 30 Days: What to Do, In Order

- 1 Confirm the client's target ACOS (or TACOS) and monthly budget before touching bids.
- 2 Audit existing campaigns: pause anything with zero sales and high spend (see the STR Winner/Bleeder Scanner).
- 3 Launch or verify an Auto campaign to harvest search-term data if the catalog is new.
- 4 Pull the Search Term Report weekly; move proven converting terms to Exact campaigns.
- 5 Add negative keywords for irrelevant or zero-order high-spend terms.
- 6 Check placement performance (Top of Search vs. Rest of Search vs. Product Pages) and adjust bid modifiers.
- 7 Report weekly using the Client PPC Performance Report Template.

This is a general framework. Every account, category, and client goal is different — treat the numbers above as starting points, not fixed rules.